
Republicans Started a Nationwide Fight Over Redistricting. Did They Just Lose?

Published by

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Estimated reading time

9 min

Added on

2026-04-23

Address

<https://slate.com/news-and-politics/2026/04/virginia-redistricting-vote-trump-midterms.html>

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In 2020, Virginia voters amended the state constitution to put redistricting in the hands of a bipartisan commission to reduce partisan gerrymandering. Less than six years later, on Tuesday night, Virginia voters said to hell with it all and approved a ferocious Democratic gerrymander of their state. The new map, if it survives some last legal checkpoints, is expected to give Democrats 10 of the state's 11 congressional seats this fall, a four-seat increase from the current map.

The referendum result neutered whatever advantage Republicans had built—or even builds out a small one for Democrats—in the midcycle redistricting war that Donald Trump kicked off last summer by insisting Texas Republicans redraw their maps. That doesn't mean that there's anything in the long run for anyone to celebrate here. This redistricting war will continue, aggressively, into 2028. Millions and millions of Americans now live in newly rigged and incoherent districts that don't adequately represent them. A new norm for state legislatures to redo maps when it suits their fancy, instead of every 10 years, has been established.

But for 2026, at least, Republicans initiated a dirty process and were met with a successfully dirty response from national Democrats. And if Republicans keep pushing, it will be “maximum warfare, everywhere, all the time,” House Democratic Leader Hakeem Jeffries, potentially a hair too hyped up on Tuesday night, said in a statement.

That Jeffries line sounded familiar. Last summer, when the White House was kicking off its attempt to insulate the House GOP majority by taking on midcycle redistricting, a GOP operative [told](#) Politico that Trump's team was applying “maximum pressure on everywhere where redistricting is an option and it could provide a good return on investment.”

The unofficial launch date of this process, the [brainchild](#) of White House political aide James Blair and Republican mapmaker Adam Kincaid, was July 15, 2025, when Trump [told](#) the Texas Republican delegation that he was eyeing a five-seat pickup in the state with redrawn maps.

“This totally set our world on fire, and flipped us upside down,” John Bisognano, president of the National Democratic Redistricting Committee, told me in an interview on Tuesday. The NDRC had been founded by former Attorney General Eric Holder, in coordination with President Barack Obama and then-Speaker Nancy Pelosi, ahead of the 2020 Census to narrow the yawning structural advantage in the House that Republicans had formed over the previous couple of redistricting cycles.

“Donald Trump was clearly, I would say very clearly, threatening to bring us back to that age of 2014, 2010, when it was nearly impossible for both parties to compete for the House of Representatives,” Bisognano said.

The logic of Blair and others was that the party coalition had changed the previous five years—especially with Hispanic voters in south Texas shifting sharply red—so if they had the opportunity to solidify those shifts into seats, they should take it. Trump had a more characteristic description of the dynamic in Texas.

“I got the highest vote in the history of Texas,” Trump [said](#) in early August, “and we are entitled to five more seats.”

Republicans further believed that Democrats would struggle to respond in kind because of the way blue states had hamstrung their own mapmaking discretion. Blue states like California, Virginia, Colorado, and Washington had amended their constitutions to put redistricting into the hands of bipartisan commissions. Red states didn’t futz around with such good-government preciousness, and after Texas changed its map, the push would continue in Missouri, Ohio, North Carolina, Florida, and Indiana.

“And so we found ourselves in this current moment, with this massive decision before us,” Bisognano said. “AG Holder”—who still chairs the NDRC—“quickly was able to come to the reality that we need to adjust our own tactics in order to try to rebalance the playing field.” Blue-state constitutional safeguards against gerrymandering, in other words, needed to be put on hiatus—and quickly.

And so California moved first and set the model for Virginia to follow. Through a referendum that voters approved late last year, California suspended the maps drawn by the California Citizens Redistricting Commission through the 2030 cycle and replaced them with new maps giving Democrats up to five new seats. That neutralized Texas’ move.

Republicans enjoyed mixed success in their next targets.

Ohio Republicans, who had the opportunity to vaporize up to three of the state’s five incumbent Democrats, chose a safer play out of fears that Democrats might put a new map up for statewide referendum. They [cut a deal](#) with Democrats that would put two seats in further (though by no means insurmountable) jeopardy for Democrats, while actually improving the odds for Democrats in the third.

In North Carolina, where maps are now redrawn every cycle as a matter of course, Republicans further endangered one Democrat, Rep. Don Davis, by putting him in a seat that Trump won by 12—though in a good cycle for Democrats, he’ll still have a shot.

Missouri Republicans did approve a new map that cracked Rep. Emanuel Cleaver’s longtime Kansas City district, though there’s a chance the new map is [averted](#) for this cycle if opponents can successfully get a referendum on the ballot.

And in one of the most public fights, the Indiana Senate rejected proposed new maps after an all-out pressure campaign from the administration. (“J.D. Vance was using Indianapolis’ airport like a hub for Air Force Two for like two months,” as Bisognano put it.)

Democrats had their share of misfires, too. The Maryland state Senate refused to eliminate the state’s lone Republican, Rep. Andy Harris, despite a similarly public pressure campaign from national Democrats and Gov. Wes Moore. The Supreme Court [halted](#) a Democratic effort to redraw GOP Rep. Nicole Malliotakis’ Staten Island district.

Democrats needed another big splash beyond California and [the lone Utah seat](#) that a judge gifted them—especially with an eager Gov. Ron DeSantis awaiting his turn to redraw Florida. It would have to be Virginia.

The Virginia gerrymander is, on its own terms, a dirty job. This is a light-blue state that Kamala Harris only won by 5 points in 2024, and the proposition was to give Democrats a 10-to-1 representational advantage in Congress. The districts in the [new map](#) are painful on the eyes. Four districts extend southward from the northern Virginia suburbs of D.C. to drown out rural communities with which they have nothing in common. The 7th District, which looks like a scorpion, is appropriately dastardly, stretching from mountainous country in the western part of the state straight to expressways over the Potomac River into Washington D.C.

What especially upset Virginia Republicans already apoplectic over this, though, was the language of the referendum itself: It asked voters whether they wanted to suspend the existing, neutral map through the 2030 census and adopt the new map in order to “restore fairness in the upcoming elections.”

There’s nothing fair about this map for Virginia Republicans. And by all means, they should address their many reasonable complaints to James Blair.

The next and likely final state to watch is Florida, where Gov. Ron DeSantis plans to begin a special session on April 28. While he has talked a big game about adding potentially another five seats, that may just be impossible. Florida starts from a significantly gerrymandered position—far more than Texas was. And, as is the case with Texas, those promises of “five seats,” based on who would have won them in a 2024 pro-Republican environment, won’t necessarily stand up in a good Democratic year. If DeSantis pushes too hard, he could risk a “dummymander,” in which the Republican vote is spread too thin and Republicans end up worse off than they were before. The Florida Republican delegation is concerned about this, and Jeffries named names in his warning to Republicans in his Tuesday night statement.

“We will aggressively target for defeat Mario Díaz-Balart, Maria Elvira Salazar, Carlos Giménez, Kat Cammack, Anna Paulina Luna, Laurel Lee, Cory Mills, and Brian Mast,” Jeffries said. “We are prepared to take them all on, and we are prepared to win.”

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The end of the 2026 battle, then, may be within sight, with a rough outcome determined: basically a wash, but possibly favoring Democrats if the political wind stays at their back. But the war will rage on into 2028.

One shoe that hasn't dropped in time to affect 2026 maps is the Supreme Court decision in *Louisiana v. Callais*, which could neuter Section 2 of the Voting Rights Act and, with it, its protection of majority-Black congressional districts. If the Supreme Court does land that way, Republican states across the South will eliminate one majority-Black district after another, giving Republicans an opportunity to net maybe another dozen seats. That would compel more Democratic states like Colorado, Washington, Illinois, New York, New Jersey, and others to respond in kind by further gerrymandering their states.

Democrats had tried and failed to ban partisan gerrymandering when they controlled both chambers of Congress under the Biden administration. And when I spoke to Bisognano the day of the Virginia referendum, there was a lightly apologetic undertone to the conversation. He mentioned how “we did not want this war, but it’s certainly the war we’re in,” and how it was difficult for Eric Holder and other Democratic redistricting leaders to come to the conclusion that this aggressive path was the one they needed to pursue. How bad they truly felt, we don’t know. But with the end of the arms race nowhere in sight, Bisognano said that his “genuine hope” was that Democrats could pass national legislation to ban partisan gerrymandering and midcycle redistricting—either with or without Republican votes.

I doubt we’ll ever see the day that congressional Republicans sign on to legislation compelling states to give up their freedom to draw whatever maps they want. But perhaps the nuke that just dropped on Republicans in Virginia is the moment that starts winning converts.

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